I Don't Love You Anymore

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/52218217.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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by WitchBitchAddi

Summary

Inspired by "Awesome Party, Dude!" and "Awesome Party, Reprise!" both by Sorry Mom.

Catra returns to the home she grew up with for a party after her caretaker passed away.
Confronted by the memories of her childhood, Catra is faced with a decision: chase the girl she's always loved, or run.

Notes

Trigger warnings for:
- substance use (Cigarettes and alcohol).
- Brief mention of lung cancer
- Puke/vomit.
- Everyone is a very flawed person.

See the end of the work for more notes

God I look fucking awful .

Catra tightened the belt around her waist, and grabbed her jacket. This was going to be a mess.

Entrapta was waiting for her outside her dorm in its bright orange prius that somehow still worked. Catra ducked into the passenger seat and began putting on her dark blue lipstick. *I hate blue.*

"I like the blue! You look amazing in it!"

"Thanks for driving me Entrapta. You really didn't have to."

"Sure, you ready?"

Catra nodded and the car lurched forward.

It was only a twenty minute drive to her childhood home from campus, which was plenty of time for Catra to realize how horrible of an idea this was. She hadn't seen Adora since junior year, more than five years ago. Five years since Adora had stabbed her in the back, five years since she'd finally had enough of the bullying and decided to get the fuck out.
She felt a sort of obligation, though. Ms. Bright had thrown these annual parties, and this was the first one since she'd gotten sick and, well, since she'd passed. It was something Catra had to do.

The house looked the same, mostly. The paint was peeling on the siding, and the brick looked dirtier. It seemed like Adora wasn't taking care of the house nearly as much as Ms. Bright had. Whatever. She didn't like the house much anyway. It's not like Ms. Bright's entire life had been dedicated to making sure the place looked nice or anything like that. It's not like Adora hadn't even had the decency to show up to her own mother's funeral or anything.

"Catra. We're here."

She shook herself out of her thoughts and prepared to get out of the car when she saw Adora out front. She kept looking at her phone, anxiously tapping away, and then looking around. Looking for someone. Catra ducked down. *This was a fucking mistake.* "Entrapta we need to go. Now. I can't do this shit."

"Hey, hey," it cooed, "It'll be okay. This will be good for you."

"No it fucking won't. I don't want to be here. I don't want to see her, I don't want to see any of them."

"Fine. Stay in the car then. I'm going in. Scorpia is here already and I'd really like to go in and say hi."

Catra sucked air through her teeth. Fuck it. *I can do this.*

"Okay, but just until ten, then we're getting the fuck out.

"One AM, no earlier." Entrapta wore a mischievous grin that made Catra want to punch it.

"Eleven?"

"Midnight."

"Fine."

Entrapta began walking across the lawn toward the front door. Adora noticed it and gave it a small wave, and then ushered it inside. As soon as Adora and Entrapta disappeared from view, Catra made a rush for the door.

The first thing she noticed upon walking inside was the paint on the walls. *Green? Ms. Bright fucking hated green. What the fuck is Adora doing to this place?* All the furniture had been rearranged completely.

The music had been loud enough to be heard clearly from outside, but now that she was inside, she realized how deafening it was. Classic college party. *Adora used to be such a frat dude.* It

was the opposite of what Ms. Bright would have wanted. The lights were dimmed, with red and purple string lights illuminating the mass of bodies writhing across Catra's old living room floor through the fog. *Who the hell gets a fog machine for a party?*

Only one thing to do - Catra headed directly for the kitchen. And had to choke back a sob as soon as she entered. The entire room was different. The kitchen had been her favorite place in the whole world. The place that Adora and she had always met at the end of the day. The place they had their first kiss. Against the fridge, the fridge that was different now. Everything was different now. She grabbed a solo cup from the stack and filled it to the brim with punch, knocking the entire cup back in one go. It was way too strong. *Who puts whiskey into punch?* Thinking about it, that's just the thing that Adora would do. Adora wasn't smart. If she had been she wouldn't have gone and fucked up her relationship so badly. *She wouldn't have rejected me* . If she had been smart Catra would never have had to leave this house.

Some random girl she had never seen before complimented her on her outfit, that hideous blue shirt and short-shorts with torn fishnets. Out of the corner of her eye she clearly saw Adora on the other side of the room, laughing and dancing with everyone.

Wait, is that Perfuma? Her stomach churned as she heard Adora's belly laugh ring across the house over every other noise, laughing at a joke made by one of Catra's childhood bullies. Her eyes panned across the room and saw Glimmer was present as well. If only Molly were here, then the trifecta of Catra's worst nightmare could make a reappearance from highschool.

The electronic music shifted suddenly, and Catra heard words blaring from the speakers. "Through the best of times…" Her stomach sank further. Sure enough Adora let out a cheer and charged for the center of the room to dance.

Catra couldn't tear her eyes away. She hated it, she hated Adora. She hated everything about this stupid fucking party. Yet here she was, ready to join Adora and dance to the song the two had

shared so many years before. Here she was, completely entranced by her ex.

"...You're a spine-less lib-er-al…" Some girl came up to Adora, and, to Catra's surprise, Adora wrapped her hands around the girl's waist. And then leaned in for a kiss. The girl wrapped her hands around Adora's neck and sank further into the embrace.

Fuck this.

Catra grabbed another drink and headed directly for the porch.

The porch, it seemed, wasn't there, which Catra found out rather quickly when she took a step out the back door, and instead of finding hardwood, found air. She lurched forward, concrete rapidly approaching her face, when someone grabbed the back of her shirt, stopping her descent.

"Woah! Hey Wildcat, you alright?" Scorpia planted Catra back on her feet.

"Fuck off." Her voice was far shakier than she cared to admit. This whole party was such a bad idea, she should have just stayed home. "Thanks for the save."

"Yeah, no problem. You, uh, you alright?"

"Yeah fucking wonderful, it's not like…" Catra realized she was about to spit out something she'd rather her best friend not hear, and stopped herself.

"... Like what?"

"Nothing. Just drop it." Catra plucked her pack of spirits out from her bag and lit one, taking in a deep breath; letting the nicotine overwhelm her senses. She sat down on the concrete step she had nearly tumbled off of, taking another puff. "There used to be a porch here, you know?"

Scorpia, sensing the change in tone, sat down as well, half off the stair so as not to crowd Catra too much. “Yeah?”

“Yeah.”

Catra let the silence carry for a moment as the gentle buzzing in her head increased, and the voices in her head decreased. “I guess nothing’s ever quite the same. But I thought, well, I thought things would be more the same, you know? She’s changed so much of this place.” She paused to smoke a bit more. “It hurts. I think. To see the place I grew up in so different. It feels disrespectful to Ms. Bright for it all to have changed.”

Scorpia opened her mouth, thought better of it and closed her mouth, paused for a moment, and then spoke, “I know there’s a lot of bad memories here. Are you, well, are you doing okay? Do you need to go home?”

Catra paused for a moment, then shook her head slowly. “I think I’m okay. I just had a moment.”

“What… what do you think caused it?” Scorpia was clearly choosing her words carefully, probably aware that the slightest misstep would throw Catra right back into the spiral.

Catra barked out a laugh, then bit her tongue. No use pushing Scorp away yet. Not when she was trying to help. “That bitch. Whatever their name is.”

“Glimmer?”

“No, I fucking remember Sparkles. I could never forget them. No, I mean Adora’s new girl.”

“Oh. I think someone said her name was Clara.” Scorpia paused, then, as carefully as possible, pushed forward. “I think, well, you know, I think maybe, you might like her?” Seeing Catra’s expression sour she continued, “I just mean she seems really similar to you, you might give her a chance. For Adora’s sake?”

"Fuck you! Fuck Adora. She's ruined everything here, and she's ruined my life. She doesn't deserve a chance." Catra snapped despite herself, and watched Scorpia's face fall. "I'm sorry Scorp, I didn't… fuck. I didn't mean to snap. I'm sorry, okay? I just. I'm not in the mood to talk about that right now."

Scorpia raised her hands in a sign of surrender and nodded. But she didn't get up and leave. So that was something.

Catra took a last hit from the cigarette and put it out on her boot. "I guess I just don't like that she gets to be happy. And I don't."

Then the door swung open behind them, and the pair jumped up to allow the person through.

It was Perfuma. Wearing her typical hippie bullshit romper, just like she used to. Catra's stomach churned, again.

"Oh, hey! Sorry about that, you guys; almost tripped over you!" She turned toward Scorpia. "I'm Perfuma, it's lovely to meet you."

Scorpia was bright red, clearly enamored with the girl in front of her. "Scorpia." She managed to make her mouth work enough to get out her name.

"And you! What name are you going by these days? You look good! Positively radiant. I *love* the blue on you!" Catra began to retort, but Perfuma pressed on. "Dear, I do need to apologize…" she leaned in very close to Catra's left ear so that only they could hear, "... I treated you *so* horribly all those years ago. I hope you can find it in you to forgive me."

Despite the apology, her voice made Catra's skin crawl. "Fuck you Perfuma."

To her credit, Perfuma looked genuinely taken aback by Catra's response, and, further to her credit, decided to take her cue and walk away. Once she was out of earshot, Scorpia piped up.

" *That* was Perfuma? The one that bul- er- you know. Wasn't super nice to you in middle school?"

"Yeah, and highschool. She's a grade A bitch. Or at least she was. And I saw your face — don't even think about it Scorp."

"Yeah. Yeah, got it."

"I think I'm going to head back inside and get another drink."

Without waiting for a response, Catra opened up the door and stepped back into the cacophony of conversations. She grabbed another drink, downed it, and filled up again. The thoughts about being careful or responsible with her drinking had completely disappeared the moment she saw Adora again. Speaking of Adora, there she was, flailing her arms around and dancing with a bunch of her college friends. She looked so stupid dancing. *I'm not going to ask you to dance* . She pushed the sudden thought from her brain with another gulp of shitty alcohol.

She could have stood there for hours watching Adora bounce up and down. Maybe she did. Her stomach fluttered and her blood pounded in her temples. She gulped down another bit. *It's always been Adora.* She finished the drink. *Fuck you* . The thought was aimed at no one in particular. Maybe herself. Maybe at Adora. For a second she was overcome with the insane thought that Adora could actually hear her thoughts, hear the monologue running in the back of Catra's brain that was constantly yelling at her. Adora turned. The two made eye contact. *I need to get out of here.* Catra felt like passing out. She rushed for the basement door. Hopefully there would be some refuge in her old bedroom.

Instead, all she found was Clara, passed out in the bed that used to be hers, a bit of vomit that had missed the wastebin dripping from the bedsheets. *Fucking hell* .

"Hey! Wake the fuck up!" *This is a bad idea* .

Clara didn't move at all.

She hated the girl. Hated her for receiving what Adora couldn't give her. "You ugly bitch! Wake. The. Fuck. Up!" With each word, Catra shook Clara's shoulders. She still didn't move at all. *Shit* .

"Clara. Seriously. Wake up." Catra was starting to panic now. The girl was clearly in a bad way. Catra could just walk away. Pretend she hadn't seen Adora's girlfriend completely poisoned by alcohol. She didn't have to help at all.

But something tugged at Catra. Something that made her stay.

She tried one more time, opening Clara's eyelids - they were dilated to hell, and unfocused. She didn't wake up. The cold pounding in Catra's chest was making it hard to breathe, and she realized she was starting to hyperventilate. Not fully thinking, she slapped the girl as hard as she could across the face.

This time, at least, Clara murmured something. *Well at least she's not dead.* But she didn't wake up. Catra searched her brain, she knew she had some information. Freshman year of college. She'd taken a course about overdoses. What was it? *Sternum rub.*

Catra balled her hand into a fist and firmly pressed her knuckles in the center of Clara's chest. And then she vigorously rubbed back and forth. *How long am I supposed to do this? 10 seconds. Okay. 4…5…6…*

Clara finally snapped into consciousness, her eyelids fluttering open. Her eyes were still unfocused, like she'd been concussed or something, and her pupils were still completely blown out. She moved her head slightly, barely registering Catra's form over her.

"Wha the fug?!" Clara lashed out her arms, slapping Catra across the face, in a desperate attempt to draw away from the unfamiliar figure looming over her. She grabbed her chest, sudden pain clearly radiating outward from where Catra had given her a proper sternum rub. Then, she clutched her stomach, cheeks puffing out. Catra thought quickly and grabbed the wastebin, thrusting it

under Clara's right as the drunk girl unleashed another round of mostly liquid.

"Hey. Hey, you're okay. Just breathe, and let it all out." Catra gently stroked Clara's back in circles, holding her hair back as Clara bent down again, puking more.

Clara nodded at Catra's soft encouragement. When the girl had finished - or seemed to be done - Catra grabbed the water bottle that was perched precariously at the edge of the nightstand, assuming it was Clara's, and passed it to the girl.
"Drink a little bit, okay? You're going to need it."

Clara nodded softly again, taking the water bottle from Catra with shaking hands, pale as a ghost, and sweating profusely. She drank a few sips, then collapsed back into bed.

For a moment, nothing else mattered. All that was important was making sure this girl was safe and okay. It didn't matter that she was Adora's new girlfriend. It didn't matter that she had the same curly hair as Catra, or a similar nose. It didn't matter that she had had on the same wings as Catra (though only one really remained, as the girl's tears and sweat had mingled and washed away most of the black eyeliner).

Catra smiled, and gently caressed the girl's forehead.

"How are you feeling?"

The girl groaned a little in response, shutting her eyes again.

"Too bright?"

Clara nodded, and Catra momentarily left her side to shut off the ceiling light. She clicked on the little lamp shaped like a mushroom, which casted a warm orange around the room, and sat back down next to the girl, careful to avoid the vomit still clinging to the blankets.

Clara hummed a noise of contentment at the shift in lighting, and at Catra's gentle hands in her hair.

Just to be safe, Catra took the girl's pulse. It seemed normal enough. She was no doctor, but 76 beats per minute seemed acceptable based on what she remembered from her many interactions with medical workers. Alcohol poisoning was no joke, but the girl seemed okay, now at least.

After a minute or two, Catra had the girl drink some more water.

They stayed like that for at least twenty minutes as Catra's thoughts ran wild. Mostly they were about Adora. How much this all hurt. As she looked down at the now peaceful girl below her, a snore gently peeling from her throat, she felt that all-too familiar ping of regret. Her chest seized. Adora had chosen this girl over her. In a way. And who was Catra to blame the blonde? Catra was broken. She always would be. She was a fuck up. Too traumatized to exist with another person. And this Clara girl, she seemed like a perfect replacement for Catra. All the way down to the ripped fishnets and combat boots. And blue shirt. A different shade, sure, and she was wearing a skirt, not short-shorts. But still. She was a mirror of Catra. Flawed, probably, but not shattered. Not broken. A better version of Catra. Probably. She didn't know the girl.

Catra batted away a tear forming in her eye. She had to get it together.

"Catra?" Adora's voice was soft, a little confused. She clearly was not expecting to walk in on her ex gently stroking her current girlfriend's hair. She must have come down to check on Clara.

Suddenly, everything was too much for Catra. All the hurt, the isolation of the last five years, the betrayals, the bullying from Adora's friends, the changes to the house, Clara. It all was too, too much.

Catra breathed in a massive breath of air, pinching the bridge of her nose to stop herself from exploding.

Catra didn't turn around, her back still mostly to Adora. But she could feel Adora's eyes blazing into her, then shifting down, to check on the now-sleeping girl. She heard Adora's footsteps approach, and then Adora was right next to her. Her heat radiating against Catra's skin, her arm brushing against Catra's as she gently shook Clara. "Clara, are you okay? Do you need anything?" She noticed the vomit. "Oh, shit, yeah I'll get a towel."

Adora completely ignored Catra. Which, somehow, hurt more than anything else that night.

Adora shook Clara again, trying to stir her.

Against her own will, Catra heard her voice hiss out between her teeth. "Adora. Leave her alone. She's resting."

The blonde girl's head sprung up to look at her. Her face was creased with concern, but behind her eyes was… something. Something else. Hatred. Probably. Catra's stomach sank, and she felt her throat get tighter.

"Is she okay?"

"She just threw up a bunch. Very kind of you to check on her nearly thirty minutes later. Or — wait, how long has she been down here?"

Adora shrugged. Stupid Adora.

All of the emotions came rushing forward. White hot. Anger. Pure unadulterated anger. Adora must have seen it flash across her eyes, because she recoiled slightly, retreating into herself. Which just made Catra feel guilty. And worse. And angrier. *Why does she get to be afraid of me? After everything she's done to me.*

"She should wake up. Drink some water." Adora's words were muffled by the roaring in Catra's ears. "Catra. Go get a towel, yeah?"

That was it. *How fucking dare she give me orders* .

She tried to keep it in. She tried to respond. Tell Adora that she was comforting Clara, that Adora could fetch her own stupid towel. But then Adora nudged Catra. Their eyes met. Adora raised an eyebrow expectantly, and that was it. That was enough. All of those boiling emotions burst forth, like the first fracture in a dam.

"Adora. Shut the fuck up." Catra hissed out those words, trying her best to remain calm.

Adora, clearly, did not see the effort she was making. "Woah. You ignore me all night, and the first thing you say to me is for me to shut up? What the fuck is happening?" Her voice was loud. Too loud. It made Catra wince. And her rage boil over.

Catra's head snapped to a focus, making direct eye contact with her ex. Her eyes blazed. "What is happening? You want to know? What is happening is that you changed everything in this fucking house. You aren't keeping up with the lawn, or the front, you know how much that meant to your mom. And then you let this fucking cunt sleep in my fucking bed!" She hadn't meant to call Clara that. She didn't hate the girl. The girl hadn't done anything. But she was so, so goddamn mad at Adora. She couldn't keep it in. Her words kept rushing out, "What the fuck do you mean 'what is happening'?" Catra stood up suddenly, Clara stirring slightly at the sudden movement. She was toe to toe with Adora. Her forehead level with Adora's nose. She had to look up just to see her. But she felt so tall, taller than Adora. She towered over the girl with her emotions, with her fury. "God you sound so fucking stupid. I'm done. I'm fucking leaving. Cool *fucking* party dude." As she said those last words, she pushed her hand into Adora's chest as shoved, as hard as she could. Adora stumbled back, surprised, her hurt written all over her face. Catra rushed past Adora, ignoring that Glimmer and Entrapta had come down the stairs — investigating the commotion.

This is what I wanted, right? She'd wanted Adora to be hurt. She'd wanted Adora to feel the same pain and anguish that she had felt since the day Adora rejected her. Since the day Adora had told her that she couldn't love her as she was. That Catra being a

woman was a deal breaker. But here Adora was, dating a girl that looked so similar to Catra. *Fuck you Adora* .

Catra rushed for the back door, needing another cigarette. The old trampoline was still there, and she made direct for the other side, hiding herself behind it, and lit another.

Instantly she calmed down. And then a wave of guilt hit her like a truck. She sank to a squat, and desperately swatted away at a tear forming in her eye.

She screamed into the night. A scream of anger and anguish and frustration. All of her emotions came boiling up inside her and bursting out. Again.

"Fuck!"

Fuck fuck fuck fuck fuck. She had given it a shot. Tried to come back to this house, back home, and this is what she gets. Of fucking course it is.

Then, a hand wrapped around Catra's wrist. Fire instantly shot up her arm and into her chest. She knew this grip, knew this feeling. It still felt the same. "Hey. Cat. Talk to me."

Catra didn't even try to pull away from Adora. She just took another hit from the cigarette, and let a tear roll down her cheek.

"You still smoke the same cigarettes, huh?" Adora's voice was gentle. Too gentle. This wasn't how she was supposed to respond. Adora was supposed to be mad at her. Pissed. Hurt and angry. She had every right to be after Catra's outburst in the basement.

Catra was confused.

She turned, then, to look at Adora. Not her face. She wasn't ready for that. The girl was wearing a simple tank top and jeans. Her feet caught Catra's eyes.

She laughed, hollow. “Yeah. Suppose I do. You’re still wearing those same shitty sneakers.”

“Yeah.”

Catra turned to look at her oldest friend, her ex, the person she’d grown up with. She was still too thin for his own good. Still too good looking for her own good too, her blonde hair ragged and sweaty from dancing, still growing out from the stupid boyish cut it used to be. Her piercing blue eyes and eyelashes most girls were completely envious of. She’d been into her long before Adora even knew she was a woman. She was gorgeous. *She’s too much for you. You don’t deserve her. I don’t love you anymore anyway. I don’t love you anymore.*

“I think…” her voice caught in her throat. “I think I’ll go now.”

She didn’t move to leave. And Adora didn’t let go. Then Adora moved. She wrapped her arms around Catra, holding her tight. “It’s good to see you. I’m sorry. That I haven’t been good enough.”

Catra was completely lost. *What the fuck am I supposed to say?* This was the person that she thought she’d be with forever, someone she had done her best to completely push out of her brain.

Adora continued for Catra. “I know it’s been hard for you, without mom. I know how much she meant to you. I know she was basically your mom too, after yours passed. I’m sorry I didn’t reach out.”

Finally Catra managed to choke out some words, breaking the hug. “Why weren’t you at the funeral?”

“I…” she hesitated. “I couldn’t stomach it. Seeing her. It’s my biggest regret.”

“Hey.” She was looking at the ground. Catra reached forward, hesitantly, and then touched her chin, raising her face so that

Adora's eyes met hers. "Funerals are for the living, not the dead. You are okay. I get it. I almost didn't go, too." It hurt to admit that outloud. She hadn't told anyone that.

"No I -" A tear pooled in the corner of her eyes - "I let you down, Cat. I fucked up. Not just the funeral. But before that. I'm… I'm sorry."

Catra wiped away Adora's tear, and pulled her into another hug. Despite herself, she couldn't push away the flush that rose through her at the body contact. She further couldn't ignore it when Adora gently placed a kiss on her neck.

It was probably just the alcohol. Probably the nicotine. Probably anything that made it impossible for Catra to break away. She couldn't help herself. Adora kept kissing, her teeth gently grazing against Catra's jugular. Catra closed her eyes, she could have wept at how good it felt. Then she had a thought.

"Wait." She pushed Adora back.

"I'm sorry. I'm sorry I didn't mean to-"

"No, no it's just. What about the girl in the basement? Clara."

Adora's face went blank. It was like she didn't know who Catra was talking about. Catra could see the gears turning. And then it clicked. Adora stepped back. Then she took another.

"Adora, wait."

She just shook her head, turned, and ran back inside, leaving Catra all alone.

Catra broke. Not just her heart. It felt like her entire chest split in two. Her mind shattered into tiny pieces. Her ribs hurt. Her legs wobbled. Her arms felt heavy. Her stomach twisted into the tightest knot it had ever known.

Too much. Adora was too much.

Mercifully, one clear thought emerged, forcing its way to the front of Catra's mind. Giving her at least some clarity.

Fuck it. I'm going home .

Catra marched through the back door, pressed through the crowd of bodies, and reached the front door. She turned the knob, opened it, and then felt someone grab her other wrist. She turned back. It was Adora, again.

"Stay?" Over the music she might as well have been mouthing the word.

"Fuck you Adora." She hoped she'd get the message.

Catra caught the last bus home.

Catra's phone buzzed for the third time in a minute. Which was unusual given that no one talked to her anymore. She sighed, put down her pencil, and checked her notifications.

<504-264-1253, 10:43>
hey :) thought i might invite you

<504-264-1253, 10:43>
again

<504-264-1253, 10:43>
i know you didnt show last year but itd be nice to see you again. its been a while.

Whatever . She was pretty sure it was Adora. Who else could it be? She must have gotten a new number, since her old one had been blocked since the last disastrous party two years ago. She wasn't about to try her luck again.

Catra picked up the pencil and went right back to the sketch she was working on. Her boss wouldn't be happy if the new design was late, again.

<504-264-1253, 13:31>
think about it at least?

Catra rolled her eyes and kept working.

<504-264-1253, 16:53>
u have read receipts on

I suppose I do . It was too late by this point. And Adora was being persistent. Either she blocks the number, again, or she responds.

Catra picked up the phone again, and quickly typed a "Fuck you Adora." Then she deleted it. "Sorry, not interested." Delete. *Fuck, what am I supposed to say here* ? "What time?" Delete. Catra tossed the phone across the room, letting it crash into the pillows on her couch. Adora was a problem for a different day, and she wasn't going to go to her stupid party.

*

Four hours later Catra was standing hesitantly in front of the house that she'd grown up in, helmet still on and concealing her face. The house was different, again. It looked more like how she remembered it growing up. The lawn was well groomed. The siding had been redone. It looked nice.

Adora was in the front lawn. She kept looking at her phone, anxiously tapping away, and then looking around. Looking for someone. Adora's hair was longer than the last time Catra had seen her. It came just below the shoulders, and in the dim lighting it looked like she had dyed the ends pink. *You look good.* She was wearing a flowy white shirt with some sort of pattern at the hems, and a tight red skirt to match her lipstick. She looked different. *You seem okay.* Last party all she had worn was a simple tank top and jeans. She looked better than good. She

looked amazing. Catra's stomach churned and fluttered. *This is bad already* .

Catra was across the street, and Adora hadn't noticed her yet. She took a deep breath, yanked the helmet off of her head, and shook her long curly hair out from the tight ponytail she rode with. *Time to get some damned closure* .

She walked confidently directly toward Adora, unzipping her leather riding jacket as she went. Adora was engrossed with her phone, and didn't notice Catra approaching until she was already within earshot.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora's head swung up, her eyes big, like a deer in headlights. She looked genuinely surprised to see Catra, but her confusion vanished quickly enough, replacing her expression with a blank slate. She was wearing eyeliner, black lining for the wings, filled in with white liner; and she had pink blue and white eyeshadow arranged neatly. It seemed like Adora had discovered how to wear makeup in the last couple years. And it was positively devastating for Catra, who had been really hoping not to fall for the person she grew up with, again. Alarm bells started to toll in Catra's mind, and she knew she couldn't stay long. She was about to turn around to walk back to her bike when Adora finally spoke.

"It's good to see you. I didn't think you'd make it."

"Me neither."

The two stood there for a moment, just looking at each other.

"I, um, like your fit." Adora said it more like a question than a compliment, which made Catra grin a little. Catra had spent at least an hour trying to figure out what to wear, and it seemed like the tight black bralette was a good choice. Though it was cold as fuck outside.

Before Catra could respond and continue the awkwardness that was this conversation, the front door opened behind Adora. Out stepped Glimmer, wearing massive platform boots that put them almost at eye level with Catra.

"Adora! There you are! We're about to open that bottle of champagne, thought you'd want to be there." Their eyes moved from the back of Adora's head to rest on Catra's face, realization mingling with confusion at her presence. "Hey, Catra. Didn't expect to see you here."

Catra felt a "fuck you" welling up in her throat, but bit it back. She'd been working with her therapist about second chances for people. Who better to give a second chance to than to the person that hurt her so much. If she was giving Adora a second - fourth, really - chance, she might as well give Glimmer one.

Glimmer actually stepped fully outside, walking down the steps to be on level with Catra and Adora. "It's… really good to see you. Can I hug you? I didn't think you'd make it."

The proposition of a hug from them almost made Catra gag. "No hug, thank you though."

"That's okay! We're just really glad you could be here. Do you want to come inside?" The way Glimmer said "we" raised a few more alarm bells. It was like they were speaking for someone else.

"You okay there Sparkles?" Catra couldn't help herself. They were just being far too nice for their usual self.

Glimmer looked taken aback, their face momentarily contorting at the childhood nickname. "Adora, we'll be right inside after you, why don't you head in?"

Adora nodded, and disappeared into the house, leaving Catra stranded with someone she thought hated her.

"Adora talked to me, you know. A few years ago. I didn't get a chance to apologize last time I saw you, but-"

Catra cut her off. "I don't want a fucking apology, Glimmer, I-" she realized that she was biting verbally again. She took a deep breath, collected herself, then continued, "Sorry – I'm working on the temper. You really hurt me. I don't think that can just go away with an apology."

Glimmer clicked their tongue, thinking, and then, "I understand completely. You want to head inside?"

Catra nodded, gave Glimmer a slight smile, then pushed past them into the house.

It was a much smaller gathering than the last time Catra had stood in this living room. There were only fifteen or so people that she could see, some she recognized from her and Adora's middle and highschool days, but some of the faces were new - they must be Adora's coworkers or something. Perfuma and Scorpia were cuddling on the couch. Catra gave Scorpia a little wave, but either Scorp didn't see it, or she ignored it. The words she'd said to Scorpia when she'd found out the two were seeing each other rang through her head. A ping of guilt seeped into Catra's chest, tightening it, making it ever so slightly harder to breathe. *Another relationship I fucked up* . Shaking herself, she made her way toward the kitchen. From the corner of her eye, she saw a familiar figure approaching rapidly. She didn't have time to duck out of the way before she was enveloped in a giant hug from Bow.

"Catra! You look amazing! How are you!" Despite the music being little more than ambiance, he was still yelling.

Catra returned the hug, quietly responding into their ear. "Hey Bow. It's good to see you too."

"I wasn't expecting to see you here. I'm glad you're here. I miss you!"

"I miss you too, dude. We should get a coffee sometime."

He smiled and nodded as Adora reappeared out of the kitchen with two drinks.

She handed one to Catra, looked at Bow, realized she only had two drinks, and handed the other to Bow. Bow shook their head and returned the cup, mouthing that he was fine. Adora shrugged and took a sip.

“So, Cat, what brings you here?” Heat shot through Catra at hearing Adora call her by her old nickname.

“You invited me, dumbass. Why else would I be here?”

Adora blushed a little and took another sip.

Catra drank with her.

“Hey, this is really good Champagne?”

“Yeah! We got a nice bottle. We have some red and white wine in the kitchen too. I got a bottle of Whistlepig if whiskey is more your style, too.”

“I guess punch and gas station bourbon wasn’t cutting it anymore?”

“Suppose not.”

The three stood in awkward silence. At least it was awkward for Catra. She caught Bow giving Adora a smile that seemed like encouragement, and Adora continued.

“So, you have a bike now?”

“What kind of question is that? You know I’ve wanted one since I was a kid.”
“Just glad to see you live your dream.”

“And you? You living the dream? How’s that Clara girl doing?”

Adora laughed out loud, her deep belly laugh that sent tingles shooting through Catra's heart. "No, no we broke up more than a year ago." She paused a bit, collecting herself, and then her face turned a bit more serious. "You could call it karma for how I treated you. She left me when I told her I wanted to start E." She got a little quieter, and Bow looked away to indicate that he wasn't listening. "Seriously, Cat, I am sorry for what I did to you."

Ice ran through Catra's veins. *What the fuck is up with everyone apologizing today?* "Yeah, well, all you did was drive me from my own goddamn home." She said it with a half smile, but Adora's face fell. Bow winced - it seemed like they were listening afterall. Or maybe Catra said it a bit too loud.

But Adora didn't leave. And neither did Bow. Catra opened her mouth to apologize when — "Hey you guys! Awe it's just like the old days, all four of us!" — Glimmer appeared out of nowhere, wrapping themself around Bow as they spoke.

At first Catra was confused, but the peck on Glimmer's cheek from Bow made the situation clear. They'd been into each other since before Glimmer became friends with Perfuma and Molly. "Hey, good for you guys. You make a good pair," She said.

Both Bow and Glimmer looked fully taken aback at the rare compliment from Catra, but they received it with grace.

Adora looked like she was dying to say something, foot tapping rapidly on the floor, and eyebrows cinched in concentration. She was adorable. Catra looked at her curiously, raising one eyebrow, which finally got Adora to break. "Hey, Catra, can we talk in private?"

Catra nodded, but before she could even take a step, she felt Adora's hand close around her wrist, dragging her outside. Fire shot through her body, and sparks crackled in the corner of Catra's vision. *Your hand on my wrist still feels the same* . Adora dragged her out to the yard, where the foundations of a porch had been laid, and beams of wood were scattered across the

lawn. Adora propped herself up against the wall of the house, and Catra followed suit, picking a cigarette out of her case.

“Still smoking spirits?”

“You’re still wearing those same shitty sneakers.”

The two smiled. Catra passed the cigarette to Adora, who took the tiniest of hits, and then coughed her lungs up, which made Catra burst out laughing. “Still can’t handle smoke I see.”

“I handle —” another coughing fit momentarily overtook her, “— handle grass fine. Just your stupid cigarettes.”

Catra chuckled. “Probably for the better. You’d be too hot if you smoked.”

“Too hot?” Adora sputtered. “I don’t think lung cancer is hot.”

Catra shrugged and grinned. “Want another hit?”

“Absolutely not, thanks.”

Catra turned, pressing her left shoulder into the wall, so that she could look directly at Adora. The flowing shirt masked her muscles, still too visible. She was still far too thin for her own good, but it seemed like the E was putting a bit of weight on her bones. Her face had noticeably shifted, it was rounder. And her eyes were brighter. Her nose was perfect for her new face, it was adorable, and perfect, and Catra wanted to kiss it. *No. I don’t love you anymore.*

“So you’re having a porch built?”

Adora grinned, shifting to press her right shoulder to the wall, directly facing Catra. “Actually, building it myself.”

“Any reason?”

“I shouldn’t have taken it out in the first place.”

Catra nodded. She couldn't disagree. "It'll look nice. You always do a good job with whatever you're working on."

Adora actually blushed — or at least it seemed like she did — it was hard for Catra to tell in the dim light.

"Nothings ever quite the same, is it?" Catra wasn't sure why she said that, it was just the first thing that came to her mind. Everything was different, but everything was still so much the same.

"It doesn't change all that much."

"I guess we just grew up?"

Adora nodded reflectively, then silence fell over the two of them. She sucked in a deep breath of air through her teeth, and then, before she could change her mind — "You look good by the way."

It was Catra's turn to blush. "Yeah." She wasn't good at compliments. She knew she looked good. She'd changed so much, even just in two years. She was proud of how far she'd come. *How do I open up to her?* She wasn't ready to open up. Not fully. But she wanted to, so badly.

The silence was turning awkward, and Catra realized she would need to break it. Adora was either dissociating or completely engrossed in Catra's face, she preferred to think it was the former. "I like your hair."

"Oh, you noticed? I'm trying out the pink! What do you think?"

"I just meant it looks good long. You look good." Adora was definitely blushing by this point. "I do like the pink though. You're pretty Adora." *Why the fuck did I say that?*

For some goddamn reason a tear was forming in Adora's left eye. Damnit. She had to do something. "Would you like a hug?"

Adora nodded, and Catra wrapped herself around her. Adora's lanky arms surrounded Catra, squeezing her tight to Adora's chest. The two stayed like that. Just holding each other.

Then the cigarette burned down to Catra's fingers, and she yelped a bit at the pain, breaking the hug. She carefully picked up the butt so as not to leave it in Adora's lawn.

"Let's head in." Catra didn't wait for Adora. She batted aside a tear that was forming. It was all too much. Adora, her hug, how goddamn pretty she was, being back in this house, everyone apologizing. Too, too much. Catra felt like she was feverish, despite the cold.

She stepped inside, and threw away the remnants of her cigarette into the nearly-full trash can. Catra's head was spinning. She felt dizzy, felt like she was going to throw up. Adora wasn't behind her anymore, she must have joined the others. Catra stumbled to the sink and downed a cup of water. It wasn't the alcohol. It wasn't the cigarette. It was Adora. She knew it was Adora. Everything about her was intoxicating. She was fucking addictive.

Images flashed through Catra's brain. The two of them together. Climbing the roof of the highschool to smoke. Walking along the train tracks. Skating down to the corner store at one AM. The last party. Adora's lips on Catra's neck. Adora's lips on her's. It was too much. She knew she couldn't possibly feel it anymore. This was too much for her. She had to leave. She had to go before she did something stupid.

It seemed like Adora didn't hate her — not anymore. Maybe. Maybe they could reconnect.

Not tonight.

It could work.

No.

I could make it work.

You don't deserve her. You don't deserve this.

Catra knew there was nothing that made her feel more intoxicated than Adora's touch. Adora's breath on her skin. Adora's face. Adora's voice. Adora. It was all Adora.

I don't love you anymore.

I don't love you anymore.

I don't love you anymore.

I think I still love you .

She had to leave. Now. The time on the microwave read 11:52. It was time to go. She stumbled through the living room, out the front door, onto the lawn. She was sober. She didn't feel sober. She felt like she was dying. Her heart was aching, torn in two. She wanted to stay. She needed to leave. *What the fuck is wrong with me* .

"Catra. Where are you going?" Adora's voice rang out from behind her.

Catra didn't respond, but she paused. She stood there, halfway between her bike and the front door of her childhood home. *What the hell do I do now?*

"Catra?"

She took one cautious step forward. Then another. Then she was walking. Walking away. She'd made her choice.

"Catra!"

She didn't turn around. She was at her bike. She reached for her helmet, and then felt a hand close around her wrist. That feeling was too familiar. It was all too much for her. She realized she was crying. Tears streaking her eyeliner.

“Catra. Where are you going?”

Broken, but as normal as she could get her voice to sound, she responded. “Home. I’m going home, Adora.”

Gentle arms wrapped around her shoulders from behind.

This isn’t working .

She tried to brush the arms away, but Adora didn’t budge.

“You are home, Cat.”

Every confusing emotion in her rushed forward, and before she could stop herself, her words rushed out. “I don’t love you anymore Adora. Stop trying.” A sob racked her body, but it worked. Adora let go. She heard her take a step back. She was free.

But her body wouldn’t work. She couldn’t move her arms. Another sob spilled out. The tears were coming in a torrent now.

“Hey. Hey, it’s okay Cat, I’ve got you. I’m going to hug you again, okay?” Adora spun Catra around, bringing her in for another hug.

Catra could barely breathe, her nose pressed into Adora’s chest. Her face was wet, and she knew she was ruining Adora’s shirt. But she didn’t try to break free. She just stood there, and let the tears roll.

Adora leaned down, and ever so gently pressed a kiss to the top of Catra’s head.

Catra’s knees shook, and gave out. The two sank to the ground as Catra’s insides melted into hot mush. She felt so safe, so loved. More loved than she had felt in eight years. She felt at home. *I don’t love you anymore* .

Adora spoke, her voice like a weighted blanket.

“Catra. Please. Stay?”

End Notes

Hey, hope you liked this piece :3
I owe a lot of thanks to Vee (@DandyVela on twt) for both inspiring me to write, and for actually taking the time to look over this fic and help workshop it with me.
So: thank you, a lot. It meant the world to me.
You can find their work here!
You can find me on twitter at @witchbitchaddi for updates as I post other stuff.
Feel free to message me wherever you can for any comments or questions!
I'm new to actually posting on AO3, so if I've done a fuck up or something with Tags or anything else, feel free (please) to let me know.

See you at the next one.
~ WitchBitch

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!